Matthias Alexander Castrén — Ethnological Lectures on the Altaic Peoples (1857)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Matthias Alexander Castrén, the parish priest's son from Tervola who taught younger children at Oulu to maintain himself, entered university meaning to enter the church, and gave his life instead to the unwritten languages of his country's kindred peoples. He received his professor's diploma from the Chancellor's own hand, opened this course within weeks, and was dead within the year.

The author's own terms

“Altaic” is Castrén's own word, in his own sense: one family embracing Finnic, Samoyedic, Turkic, Mongolic, and Tungusic peoples and languages. That was his working frame in 1851. Later scholarship kept the Uralic family — Finnic and Samoyedic — and dissolved the wider Altaic unity; the lectures are presented frame and all, as a record of 1851, not a claim for today. His period names are likewise kept and mapped: Samoyeds are the Nenets, Ostyaks the Khanty, Voguls the Mansi, Cheremis the Mari, and Zyryans the Komi, with the Udmurt among the peoples named.

The story

Matthias Alexander Castrén was born at Tervola on 2 December 1813. His father Christian, parish priest at Rovaniemi, died in 1825. Sent to school at Oulu at twelve, he helped maintain himself by teaching younger children. At the Alexander University in Helsinki he began with Greek and Hebrew, intending the church, before Finnish took hold of him.

He travelled in Lapland with Dr. Ehrström in 1838 and in Russian Karelia in 1839. From 1841 to 1844 he travelled with Elias Lönnrot beyond the Urals to Obdorsk, having first published his Swedish translation of the *Kalevala*. Then came the Siberian expedition of 1845–1849, which made his name and broke his health. His Komi grammar appeared in 1844, his Mari grammar in 1845, and *De affixis personalibus* in 1850. That year he was appointed to the new chair of Finnish language and literature at Helsinki, its first holder, and married Lovisa Natalia Tengström. He died at Helsinki on 7 May 1852, aged 38, engaged on the Samoyedic grammar he regarded as his principal work, which Anton Schiefner published in 1854.

The work and what survives

These lectures are distinct from his companion *Lectures on Finnish Mythology*, printed in 1853. Schiefner's preface records their state. The Chancellor handed Castrén his diploma in person on 14 March 1851. He opened the course on 6 May 1851, gave it four times a week through May, written with almost no preparation amid duties and ill health, and never revised it. The Voguls chapter was worked up by Borg from a draft, the full manuscript never having been found, and the Finnic peoples received only the last portion.

Printed posthumously as volume 4 of the Swedish collected works of 1852–1858, the lectures reached Schiefner's German edition at St. Petersburg in 1857 (Imperial Academy, *Nordische Reisen und Forschungen*), translated from the Swedish — two removes from delivery. In the 1857 order they treat the Tungus, Mongols, Turks, Samoyeds, Yenisei Ostyaks, and Finns, followed by five Samoyed tales and seven Tatar heroic sagas. The folder holds a complete fresh English edition of that full volume. Thirty-two manuscript volumes of his remain, now in edition by the *Manuscripta Castreniana* project.

Three folder cautions ride with the book: the Altaic frame is his 1851 frame, as above; the lectures are unfinished in the small as in the large — where the English seems abrupt, the German was abrupt first; and the peoples named are living peoples, the book a historical record, not a word over them.

Its English fortunes

No English translation of these lectures has been found after research.

The early English notice is citation, not translation: W. D. Whitney's *Language and the Study of Language* (1867) cites the German edition by page. The German survives also in a modern facsimile reprint — a reprint, not a translation.

What completing it would take

No new translation is needed; the folder's edition is complete. What remains is verification: collation against the page images of Schiefner's German, with the Voguls chapter marked for its special status as Borg's working-up from a draft. The three cautions must stay in the front matter, and these lectures must be kept distinct from the 1853 Finnish-mythology lectures. A hardened catalogue check under all title variants must precede any wording stronger than “none found after research,” and the prose word count the folder defers must be taken from the parts themselves.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/castren-mythology-lectures/ (parts p1–p6)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Matthias_Castr%C3%A9n
- https://www.studylight.org/encyclopedias/eng/bri/m/matthias-alexander-castren.html
- https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Page:Language_and_the_Study_of_Language.djvu/337 (Whitney, 1867)
- https://www.thriftbooks.com/w/ethnologische-vorlesungen-ber-die-altaischen-volker-nebst-samojedischen-mrchen-und-tatarischen-heldensagen_matthias-alexander-castren_anton-schiefner/36220694/ (facsimile reprint listing)

- Internet Archive item `ethnologischevo00schigoog`